

BUSINESS · ZERO TO ONE, PART 4

Most startups die from bad foundations, not bad ideas.

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swipe →

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Roland, what kills most startups early? 🧱

Thiel's law:

A startup **messed up at its foundation** can't be fixed later.

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Lesson 13: choose co-founders carefully 🤝

Start with people you have **real history with.**

Agree early, in writing: who owns what, who decides what, and who works full-time.

Lesson 14: build a tight team 🧩

Hire people who'd love working **together,** on a mission they believe in.

Give each person one clear job, so they're not fighting over the same work.

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Lesson 15: sales matters as much as product 📣

"Build it and they will come" is a myth.

If you can't **reach customers at a cost you can afford,** a great product still dies.

Match sales to deal size 💰

Big contracts: the founder in the room, selling personally.

Small purchases: marketing, referrals, **word of mouth.** The middle is the hardest place to be.

Lesson 16: the 7 questions ✅

1. **Engineering:** 10× better?
2. **Timing:** why now?
3. **Monopoly:** a big share of a small market?
4. **People:** the right team?

5. **Distribution:** how will you sell?
6. **Durability:** still here in 10 years?
7. **Secret:** **what do you see that others don't?**

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